

After the Story: Keep Moving

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

A companion study to *Open Hearth*

Back to the Open Hearth Fire

Pull a scrap of dry oak toward the ring before the Lehigh damp gets into it. We're going back to the South Side stacks in Bethlehem, where five old blast furnace towers cut a black skyline against a thin strip of river light, and the open-hearth bay still holds brick arches, oil puddles, and slag that crunches dry under boots. Fence mesh sagged from other hands. A crash bar waited on a plant exit door with a slack chain. Cheap green digits rode a black plastic strap.

Cole Varga is twenty-four when he tells it, but the night that matters he was twenty running that bay with Jess Marrow two steps off his right shoulder and a changed hard-hat man named Harlan coming through the fence cut in an orange vest that used to mean plant security. Jess wanted photographs of the open-hearth floor before the city put more lights on the stacks. Cole came because Jess cannot drive stick and Aunt Lila's hatchback sat up on Fourth. What followed them hit the slag in a rhythm that did not match a tired man's walk. Burned grease and river mud rode the air.

Aunt Lila had pressed the watch into Cole's hand on her porch the week she cleaned her last office on the north side. When your mouth goes quiet in a bad place, the dark gets a vote, she said. Keep speaking. Short. Plain. Keep your feet moving while you talk. The Lord hears work better than speeches. That night the watch face showed 3:00 in green, a countdown Cole had not set, and the digits held while his mouth ran the short petition: Keep us moving. Hold what I cannot see. Jesus, keep our feet. When his mouth skipped a beat, the count fell. When mute sat like a stone he chose to hold on the catwalk, the digits dropped in a rush. When he put the words back into the air with boots already moving, the count climbed again. Hands finished at the crash bar and the fence mesh. Harlan stopped at the wire and could not finish the catch while Cole's mouth stayed on the work.

Jess granted the stop at the fence. She refused the metaphysics before breakfast. Four years later she still argues that prayer is a noise brave people make when the body runs out of options. She will grant the stop. She will not grant a Person on the other end of Aunt Lila's short work order.

Tonight we sit with that open-hearth fire and ask what keep-moving prayer teaches when mute costs digits, and what Geisler and Turek confirm when truth holds under pressure and faith costs the will.

Questions to Sit With

1. Read 1 John 4:1-3, where believers are told to test the spirits, because many false prophets have gone out into the world, and where every spirit that confesses Jesus Christ come in the flesh is from God. On the slag Harlan wore a hard hat and a vest that used to mean plant security, and his gait no longer matched a tired watchman. Cole kept boots and mouth on the short work. What does testing the spirits look like when a changed man presses and your tools are a watch, a crash bar, and a petition short enough to run with?
2. Read 1 Thessalonians 5:17 and Luke 18:1, where believers are told to pray without ceasing, and where Jesus taught them they ought always to pray and not lose heart. Aunt Lila called prayer keep-moving work. Mute cost Cole digits. What changes when prayer is short work while boots move, not a campus speech you start after you have already stopped?
3. Read James 2:17 and Proverbs 3:5-6, where faith without works is dead, and where we are told to trust in the Lord with all the heart and not lean on our own understanding. Jess saw Harlan stop and still walked home unconverted. What do your own hands do with mouth and feet together when a friend will grant the stop and still call prayer noise?

The Teaching: Keep Moving

Start where Cole started. Not with a debate podium. With slag under boots, a cheap digital watch biting a wrist, brick arches in an open-hearth bay, a crash bar on a stuck plant door, fence mesh over a concrete footing, and a short petition Aunt Lila had drilled into him.

Harlan is scene pressure: once a night watchman, changed at the thinning veil, hungry for quiet mouths and stopped feet. We build tonight's fire on what Cole's mouth and hands did when the

digits fell, and on what Jess refused to pretend after the hard-hat boots faded under interstate hum.

Norman Geisler and Frank Turek open the same kit in *I Don't Have Enough Faith to Be an Atheist*. They will not let truth sit as a soft preference you rearrange when the dark presses. "Very simply, truth is 'telling it like it is.'" (Geisler and Turek, ch. 1 Can We Handle the Truth). Then the hard edge from their chapter summary: "Truth is not dependent on our feelings or preferences." (Geisler and Turek, ch. 1 Can We Handle the Truth). On the open hearth the digits did not care whether mute suited Cole. Quiet cost the count. Work held it.

Hold that against the catwalk.

Geisler and Turek press the same pressure into belief itself. Belief, they write, requires assent of the mind and of the will (Geisler and Turek, Introduction Finding the Box Top to the Puzzle of Life). Cole's mind already knew Aunt Lila's work order. His will had to keep the petition in the air while Harlan's wrong gait closed the distance. When Jess asked for a second of quiet, mute was a choice, and the green digits answered in a rush toward 2:40. Putting the words back was also a choice. Assent of the will while boots took the gate spur. Keep-moving trust. No podium speech.

They name the cost without softening it. "Christianity is free, but it can cost you your life." (Geisler and Turek, Introduction Finding the Box Top to the Puzzle of Life). Then the line that fits Jess's porch refusal as cleanly as Cole's bleeding palm: "There's a difference between proving a proposition and accepting a proposition." (Geisler and Turek, Introduction Finding the Box Top to the Puzzle of Life). The stop at the fence was proved enough for Jess to grant it. Acceptance of a Person on the other end of the short work is a different door. Cole did not baptize her grant into a conversion she has not made.

Walk the night the way the tools walked it.

First the watch. Black plastic strap. Green digits. Aunt Lila's keep-moving work order riding a wrist through wet rust and oil sheen. Geisler and Turek insist that truth still holds when a person refuses it: "Truth is truth no matter what country you come from. And truth is truth no matter what you believe about it." (Geisler and Turek, ch. 2 Why Should Anyone Believe Anything At All). Then the gravity picture: "Just as the same gravity keeps all people on the ground whether

they believe in it or not, the same logic applies to all people whether they believe it or not." (Geisler and Turek, ch. 2 Why Should Anyone Believe Anything At All). Harlan's stop at the mesh did not wait for Jess's metaphysics. The digits held while Cole's mouth worked. Truth on the wrist did not need her preference to stay true.

Second the petition. Keep us moving. Hold what I cannot see. Jesus, keep our feet. Short enough to chain with breath and boot strikes. Geisler and Turek note that the Bible itself commands Christians to question religious claims, and they list 1 John 4:1 among the places it does (Geisler and Turek, ch. 1 Can We Handle the Truth). Test the spirits. Harlan wore plant colors and hit slag wrong. Cole tested by staying on the short work Jesus' name can carry, not by climbing a podium in the bay. Scripture stands behind the paraphrase without a translation quote in our mouths: test the spirits (1 John 4:1-3). Pray without ceasing (1 Thessalonians 5:17). Always pray and do not lose heart (Luke 18:1). Faith without works is dead (James 2:17). Trust in the Lord and do not lean on your own understanding (Proverbs 3:5-6). Aunt Lila said it clean: Mouth and feet together.

Third the crash bar and the fence mesh. Hands on metal. Latch plate screaming. Blood on the bar and then on the wire. Geisler and Turek will not let willingness sit optional: "Being willing is essential. Evidence cannot convince the unwilling." (Geisler and Turek, ch. 1 Can We Handle the Truth). Jess was willing to grant the stop she saw. She was unwilling to grant the Person. That honesty belongs on this page. Cole keeps the watch on the same wrist with electrical tape over the barb tear. He does not start the countdown for show. He does not preach it at Jess. When the dark presses and his mouth wants to go quiet, his boots already know the next step, and his mouth finds the short work while his grip takes the next bar.

Geisler and Turek also warn that many who resist are refusing the will-cost of assent more than they are missing facts. Cole saw that refusal on Jess's porch and left her file open. We do the same. Proving and accepting stay two different acts. Mouth and feet stay one chain when the veil thins along the old open hearth.

The veil along the South Side stacks did not get a tidy map that night. Jess granted the stop and not the metaphysics. Cole and Aunt Lila did not close her file. We settle the keep-moving work. Speak the short petition. Hold the watch. Drive the crash bar. Pull the mesh. Put the digits back under ordinary time before you drive north with wet boots on the pedals.

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Talk about the Jess in your crew, or the Jess in your own chest. The friend who will grant a stop when hard-hat boots fade under interstate hum, and who will refuse to let anyone baptize a countdown watch and call her converted. Say out loud where you have been trying to preach a proved stop into a testimony. Cole and Aunt Lila left Jess honest. Geisler and Turek's difference between proving and accepting does not require you to fake a conversion that has not happened.

Talk about Aunt Lila's tools. She handed Cole a watch and a work order and told him to keep speaking while his feet moved. Where do you still go mute so you can hear the dark better, and then watch the count fall? Where do you still reach for a lecture when a short petition would do more work? Where do you need to quit being somebody else's Holy Spirit and simply keep mouth and feet together while your hands take the next bar?

Talk about truth that costs under pressure. Geisler and Turek will not let you treat truth as a preference you rearrange when mute looks safer. What keep-moving work have you been leaving quiet because speaking looks less like equipment and more like words? Put the petition back in your mouth this week the way Cole did: short, plain, aimed while boots move, finished with hands on the next real tool. Treat the watch as a prayer reminder.

Try this, this week. Read 1 John 4:1-3, 1 Thessalonians 5:17, Luke 18:1, James 2:17, and Proverbs 3:5-6 out loud, slow, with a pencil in your hand. Write a short margin: KEEP MOVING. MOUTH AND FEET. TEST THE SPIRITS. Then write MUTE COSTS on one side of a scrap and KEEP SPEAKING on the other. Ask which side your mouth has been living on when the dark presses and a friend will grant a stop but will not kneel. If you have been baptizing granted stops, set the watch back on the wrist in prayer and tell the truth about Jess's daylight. Learn a plain paraphrase you can say on slag: test the spirits, and pray without ceasing. Put another piece of oak on. And when a friend stays Jess, leave the granted stop where the fire can see it, refuse the fake baptism, and thank God the short work still holds when the mouth wants to go quiet.

Works Cited

Geisler, Norman L., and Frank Turek. *I Don't Have Enough Faith to Be an Atheist*. Wheaton, IL: Crossway Books, 2004.